

GLP-1 on a Budget

*Making the Most of Your Medication
Without Breaking the Bank*

Disclaimer

This book is for educational and informational purposes only. It is not medical advice and does not constitute a recommendation to start, stop, or change any medication or treatment. GLP-1 receptor agonists are prescription medications that should only be used under the supervision of a qualified healthcare provider.

The nutritional guidance, exercise information, and lifestyle strategies in this book are general wellness information and are not tailored to your individual medical situation. Always consult your doctor, registered dietitian, or other qualified health professional before making changes to your diet, exercise routine, or medication management.

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The Cost Reality

GLP-1 medications are among the most expensive prescription drugs in the world. Without insurance coverage, Ozempic and Wegovy can cost \$900–\$1,400 per month in the United States. This makes access profoundly inequitable and forces many patients to make difficult financial decisions. This chapter is about navigating that reality practically.

Understanding Your Coverage Options

Insurance coverage for GLP-1 medications varies widely. Ozempic (semaglutide 0.5mg–2mg) is typically covered for type 2 diabetes. Wegovy (semaglutide 2.4mg) is the obesity-indication version and has more variable coverage — many insurance plans exclude weight management medications.

Medicare does not cover GLP-1 medications for weight management (though this may change with legislative updates), but does cover them for diabetes. Medicaid coverage varies by state. Commercial insurance increasingly covers them for obesity with a BMI threshold, though prior authorisation and step therapy requirements are common.

The first practical step: call your insurance company and ask specifically: 'Is semaglutide or tirzepatide covered under my plan for weight management?' If yes, what are the step therapy requirements and what documentation does my doctor need to provide?

Manufacturer Savings Programs

Novo Nordisk (Ozempic/Wegovy) and Eli Lilly (Mounjaro) offer savings programs for commercially insured patients that can significantly reduce out-of-pocket costs — sometimes to as low as \$25 per month. These programs have income eligibility requirements and specific conditions.

The Novo Nordisk Patient Assistance Program and the Eli Lilly Insulin Value Program (which also covers Mounjaro for qualifying patients) are the primary options. Patient advocacy organisations including the Obesity Action Coalition maintain current information on access programs as these change frequently.

"The cost is real. The options are more numerous than most people know. Advocate for access."

Maximising Medication Efficiency

When medication is expensive, every dose needs to work as hard as possible.

Lifestyle as a Multiplier

The combination of GLP-1 medication with protein-prioritised eating and resistance training consistently produces better body composition outcomes than medication alone. This matters not just for health but for medication efficiency: better muscle preservation means better metabolic outcomes with the same medication dose.

Sleep, stress management, and the nervous system regulation practices throughout this series all support the medication's effectiveness. GLP-1 works through multiple mechanisms — including effects on the stress and reward systems — that are more available when the nervous system is regulated.

Managing Dose Escalation Strategically

You don't have to escalate to the maximum dose on the manufacturer's recommended schedule. The appropriate dose is the lowest dose that provides adequate benefit with tolerable side effects. Some people achieve their goals at lower doses than the maximum — and lower doses cost less.

Having this conversation with your provider — 'I'm having good results at this dose; can we discuss whether escalation is necessary?' — is entirely appropriate. The goal is your health outcomes, not adherence to a schedule.

"An expensive medication that works is more cost-effective than a cheaper one that doesn't. Maximise what you're already spending."

International and Compounding Options

The geographic disparity in GLP-1 pricing has created options for cost reduction that are worth understanding.

International Pharmacy Options

Semaglutide is available in many countries at a fraction of US prices. In Canada, the UK, and many European countries, the same medication costs \$100–\$300 per month. Several legal international pharmacy services allow US residents to purchase medications from licensed international pharmacies — an area of legal grey but common practice that is not federally prosecuted for personal use quantities.

NABP-accredited international pharmacies and services like Canada Drugs Direct and Canada Pharmacy operate in this space. The medications are the same molecular compound manufactured to the same standards — the price difference reflects US pharmaceutical pricing policy, not manufacturing quality.

Compounding Pharmacies

During the semaglutide shortage period (2023–2024), the FDA allowed compounding pharmacies to produce compounded semaglutide at significantly lower prices. The compounding market for GLP-1 peptides has been controversial — quality varies by pharmacy, and the FDA has issued warnings about some providers.

If using compounded GLP-1, verification of PCAB accreditation (the pharmacy compounding accreditation board standard) and prescriber oversight are the minimum appropriate safeguards. This is not a do-it-yourself option — it requires a prescribing provider and a reputable compounding pharmacy.

"Access to effective medication should not depend on where you were born or how much you earn. Know your options."
